



Introduction to CSS 10m

CSS stands for Cascading Style Sheets and, together with HTML, is considered a core technology for web development. CSS is a style sheet language that defines the appearance of a web page by defining the colours, layouts and fonts used.

In web development, there's a principle called the separation of structure from presentation. This means a web page is designed so that the content isn't tied to its style or design. HTML and CSS help follow this principle because HTML is used to build the structure of the content, while CSS is used to control how it looks. (W3C, n.d.).^{fnref:9e8177}

Before we learn about CSS, let's review the history of CSS. In 1994, Håkon Wium Lie from CERN published the first draft of CSS (Cascading HTML Style Sheets). The proposal was openly discussed on mailing lists, and in 1996, the W3C released the CSS level 1 recommendation (CSS 1). Improvements on CSS continued, resulting in the publication of the CSS level 2 recommendation (CSS 2) in May 1998. In 2011, the W3C published CSS 2.1, which fixed the errors found in CSS 2 (Bos, 2016).^{fnref:1b545c}

Since the publication of CSS 2.1, the W3C has changed the way they release specifications. They now release a set of separate documents known as modules instead of a single CSS specification. A list of the CSS specifications can be found on the W3C website.

CSS in CodePen

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You'll be familiar with CodePen-embedded windows from the HTML topic. The CodePen windows in this topic will be similar, but there are some important differences.

The CodePen windows will show three sections (HTML, CSS, and JS) and the Result view.

The CSS tab view loads by default, but you can click on the HTML tab to see what the CSS code is being applied to.

CSS written in the CSS tab of a CodePen window applies to the HTML and Result tabs in CodePen automatically.

For your CSS to work well in VS Code or any other code editor, it is recommended to use an external CSS file that is created and linked to one or more HTML files.

The following guided activity will show you how CSS can transform HTML. Example 6.1 shows a basic web page created using HTML.



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HTML

Result

EDIT ON

LIVE

```
1 <!DOCTYPE html>
2 <html lang="en">
3 <head>
4   <meta charset="UTF-8">
5   <meta name="viewport"
6     content="width=device-width,
7     initial-scale=1.0">
8   <title>My Styled
9     Page</title>
10  <link rel="stylesheet"
11    href="styles.css">
12 </head>
13 <body>
14   <h1>Welcome to my
15     webpage</h1>
16   <p>This is a simple
17     paragraph to demonstrate CSS
18     styling. Enjoy learning!</p>
19   <button>Click Me</button>
20 </body>
21 </html>
```

Resources 1x 0.5x 0.25x Rerun

Example 6.1 My web page



Using the CodePen above, select the Edit on Codepen option and add the following CSS code to see the changes that the code makes.



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```
1  /* Basic reset for consistent appearance */
2  body {
3      margin: 0;
4      padding: 0;
5      font-family: Arial, sans-serif;
6  }
7
8  /* Style for the header */
9  h1 {
10     color: #2c3e50;
11     text-align: center;
12     margin-top: 20px;
13 }
14
15 /* Style for the paragraph */
16 p {
17     color: #34495e;
18     padding: 0 20px;
19     line-height: 1.6;
20 }
21
22 /* Style for the button */
23 button {
24     display: block;
25     margin: 20px auto;
26     padding: 10px 20px;
27     background-color: #e74c3c;
28     color: white;
29     border: none;
30     border-radius: 5px;
31     cursor: pointer;
32 }
33
34 /* Button hover effect */
35 button: hover {
36     background-color: #c0392b;
37 }
```

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Complete the following task now that you have seen how CSS works with HTML.



☒ Experiment with CSS

Non-Assessed

Status: Done

Reset ↺

Try to tweak the following in the previous Codepen example:

1. **Change colours:** Try changing the **color** values in the CSS to see how the text colours update.
2. **Modify font properties:** Change the **font-family** in the body styles to see how the font changes (for example, try 'Courier New' or 'Georgia').
3. **Adjust spacing:** Modify the **margin** and **padding** values to see how spacing affects the layout.
4. **Button styling:** Experiment with different **background-color** and **border-radius** values on the button to see how they alter its appearance.

☒ I have completed the task



How did you find that task?

This topic will teach you step by step how to master CSS.

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Previous attempts ▼



Next, we'll look at CSS syntax.



Thoughts on this page?

